PUSH FOR INCLUSIVE GROWTH

Political dominance secured, chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma now faces the harder task in his second term of delivering jobs, economic growth and inclusive governance

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IANS

On May 12, 2026, Himanta Biswa Sarma returned to Dispur with the sort of mandate that removes both rivals and excuses. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) won 82 of Assam's 126 seats, crossing the majority mark on its own for the first time, while the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) touched 102, with the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and Bodoland People's Front (BPF) winning 10 seats each. Sarma—now the first non-Congress chief minister of Assam to win a second consecutive term—begins NDA 3.0 as the BJP's most unchallenged leader in the state.

That is both the opportunity and the trap. Sarma faces no serious political challenge within the BJP. Outside it, the Congress fell to 19 seats, its lowest tally in Assam. The nature of the Congress collapse gives Sarma another weapon. Eighteen of its 19 MLAs are Muslim, a fact that allows the BJP to paint the party not merely as weak but as trapped in minority politics.

But this is where the BJP's third-term challenge begins. A government with a brute majority and a diminished Opposition can easily become more decisive. It can also become more centralised, more complacent and more impatient with dissent.

THE IMMIGRANT QUESTION

Sarma has shown no sign that he intends to soften his political idiom. His intent to push the BJP's core agenda was clear from the first cabinet meeting of his second term, where the government decided, among other things, to introduce a Uniform Civil Code Bill in the first session of the state legislative assembly. Hours after being sworn in, he posted a photograph with West Bengal's new BJP chief minister, Suvendu Adhikari, and wrote: "Bad days for.... (You know who)". The post was cryptic, but in Assam and Bengal's political climate, the subtext was read as a warning to illegal immigrants.

Illegal immigration from Bangladesh remains a legitimate and unresolved concern in Assam. Sarma has repeatedly said he is not against Indian Muslims but against illegal immigrants. In his second term, however, he will have to demonstrate that this distinction is not merely a